

"There was resentment against the NTA, we changed its leadership. To oversee its structure, we set up a high-powered expert committee. And we ordered a CBI probe into the isolated incidents"

we conduct it twice for 25 lakh candidates. In CUET, we do it in blended mode. For the last eight years, from the beginning, since PMT (Pre-Medical Test) time, medical entrance tests have been happening in pen and paper. There's no comparison between apples and oranges. Both are nutritious and sweet. Both have their advantages and challenges. After all, CBSE conducts Class X and XII board exams in pen and paper. To make them foolproof is our responsibility. The NTA is the agency that conducts exams and it is its decision. The respective ministry and state government are its clients.

Q. M.K. Stalin, the chief minister of Tamil Nadu, says that NEET is unfair to rural students, especially those in villages and it is urban ones who succeed. Do you want to relook at the whole system of NEET?

This is a political stand of the DMK, that there should not be any NEET. But NEET happened on the direction of the Supreme Court. I just want to point out that last year, the NEET topper was a Tamil Nadu Board girl student from rural Tamil Nadu. Also, there is a fundamental difference in trends between the All-India Pre-Medical Test and NEET. Earlier, in the South, students used to write separate examinations for each of the state boards of TN, Andhra, Kerala, Karnataka to get a seat in one of them. Now, because of NEET, they take only one test; they are saving money and time. He or she doesn't need to appear in multiple examinations. This is a great relief and this was recommended by the Supreme Court. And this is a reformist idea that our government has implemented. From the primary trends, we see that the participation of students from SC, ST, OBC and weaker sections has gone up. They have a higher success rate. Students who have not gone to coaching centres have done well.

Q. Those who are opposed to NEET point out the Multiple Choice Question (MCQ) format vis-a-vis the others, where some think rural students are disadvantaged. Is there need for a review?

Certainly, the new reform committee of the NTA will look into that. But let me talk about Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya or JNV students, who are essentially from rural areas. You go to any JNV, you'll find two-three students who have been successful in NEET. How come? And if you go into their social profile, they come from SC, ST, OBC and weaker section backgrounds. Essentially, they come from semi-urban and rural areas. So, data is showing something else. Some people have a compulsion to create a certain narrative, but the fact on the ground does not match that. My government is committed to protect the interests of students…the interests of students of rural areas, those from the SC, ST, OBC and weaker sections of society. In 2014, there were around 51,000 medical seats. Today, we have 110,000 medical seats. So, we have doubled the number of seats, created a transparent examination system. These are our government's commitment to medical education.

"About the complaint that NEET favours urban students, if you see their social profile, the number of successful students from SC, ST, OBC and weaker sections, mostly from semi-urban and rural backgrounds, has gone up"

Q. Many experts believe that there is some nexus between coaching centres and examination setters. What is the truth?

In January, when there was a lot of anxiety over suicides, the Government of India issued an advisory on how coaching centres should perform. A few coaching centre owners were unhappy and they are at the forefront of this current movement. I fail to understand how they are related. This is number one. Number two, what is the biggest challenge? The allegation of difficult questions…that it is too urban-centric. Two things were done consciously this time. During the Covid pandemic, NCERT had introduced reduced syllabi. This time, questions were based on that reduced syllabi. Difficult questions were moderated, state boards were involved, not just the CBSE. There are more than 60 boards in the country. The kind of questions that class 12 students have to answer in their board exams, similar questions will be asked. So, those who depended on set patterns and rote learning, their interest was compromised. And one or two unfortunate incidents happened. Around that time, the NTA did some non-transparent things, like introducing grace marks, which was not